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WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND

The 12 New Watches To Know

OFF DUTY

DOW JONES | News Corp ******** SATURDAY/SUNDAY, APRIL 25 - 26, 2026 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVII NO. 96 WSJ.com ★★★★ $6.00

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **The Justice Department** said it would end its criminal investigation of Fed Chair Jerome Powell in an attempt to clear the obstacle that has stalled Kevin Warsh's confirmation as his successor. **A1**

◆ **U.S. stocks ended mixed** in Friday trading, handing the S&P 500 and Nasdaq weekly gains of 0.5% and 1.5%, respectively, while the Dow fell 0.4% for the week. **B10**

◆ **Russia's central bank** cut its key interest rate for an eighth straight meeting and said further reductions are possible despite a jump in oil prices. **A7**

◆ **Ford and Geely held** talks, now stalled, about bringing the Chinese automaker's technology to the U.S., but the companies continue to work toward a tech and manufacturing-capacity deal in Europe. **B9**

◆ **Shares of X-Energy** soared more than 30% in their stock-market debut, giving the nuclear-energy company a market valuation close to $12 billion. **B9**

◆ **Charter Communications'** stock plummeted after it tempered a full-year revenue projection and reported quarterly subscriber declines in its internet and video businesses. **B9**

◆ **Members of Hollywood's** screenwriters' union overwhelmingly approved a new contract with major studios. **B10**

Worldwide

◆ **Tensions between** Iranian leaders over talks with the U.S. have spilled into the open, highlighting how difficult it will be for Trump to secure the diplomatic win he wants to end the war. **A1, A8**

◆ **Gov. Janet Mills vetoed** a bill that would have made Maine the first U.S. state to temporarily ban data-center construction. **A2**

◆ **A group of state** attorneys general sued the EPA, alleging that the regulator violated the Clean Air Act by failing to identify areas with excessive soot. **A2**

◆ **The Trump administration** announced criminal charges, sanctions and multimillion-dollar rewards aimed at combating online scams originating in Southeast Asia and targeting Americans. **A3**

◆ **Canada approved** Enbridge's proposed multibillion-dollar expansion of a west-coast natural gas pipeline system, bolstering the country's efforts to increase exports to markets other than the U.S. **A9**

◆ **OpenAI's Sam Altman** apologized to the Canadian town of Tumbler Ridge for not alerting police sooner to the activity of the suspect in a mass shooting that killed eight people. **A5**

◆ **An appeals court blocked** Trump's order suspending asylum access at the southern border, a pillar of the president's program of discouraging migration. **A6**

PEGGY NOONAN
The right way to talk about war. **A13**

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DOJ Drops Investigation of Powell

Reversal is designed to clear opposition to Senate approval of Warsh to lead Fed

By Nick Timiraos And C. Ryan Barber

WASHINGTON—The Justice Department said it would end its criminal investigation of Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell, an attempt to clear the obstacle that has stalled Kevin Warsh's confirmation as his successor.

Jeanine Pirro, the U.S. attorney for the District of Columbia, announced the move Friday, saying her office is closing an inquiry into Powell's testimony to Congress about cost overruns on the renovation of two historic Fed buildings. A federal judge had already ruled that the grand jury subpoenas served on the Fed in January were improper and found "essentially zero evidence" of criminal wrongdoing.

Pirro wrote in a post on X that the Fed's inspector general had been asked to scrutinize the matter; Powell himself had asked the central bank's IG to review the building project last July, and that work is continuing.

"I expect a comprehensive report in short order and am confident the outcome will assist in resolving, once and for all, the questions that led this office to issue subpoenas," Pirro said.

"Note well, however, that I will not hesitate to restart a criminal investigation should the facts warrant doing so," Pirro wrote.

A Fed spokeswoman declined to comment.

An end of the probe would close a confrontation over Fed independence without modern precedent. In a January video disclosing the probe, Powell had taken the unusual step of publicly accusing the executive branch of pursuing a pretext to pressure the central bank over interest rates.

The reversal reflected how opposition to the probe from one Republican senator had forced the White House to choose between continuing

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AAMIR QURESHI/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, center, arrives in Islamabad on Friday, in a photo provided by the Pakistani government. Iran said no meeting with the U.S. was planned, but the White House said U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner would go to Islamabad for talks with Iranian officials. Vice President JD Vance will travel to the Pakistani capital, if there is progress.

Iran Divisions Frustrate Peace Efforts

By Benoit Faucon, Laurence Norman and Summer Said

Tensions between Iranian leaders over talks with the U.S. spilled into the open this week, highlighting how difficult it will be for President Trump to secure the diplomatic win he wants to end the war.

The disagreements were apparent in the first round of talks earlier in April. Mediators said Iran turned vague when pressed by the U.S. for specifics on issues it had said it was willing to discuss, people familiar with the matter said.

It is now becoming clearer that there are deep divisions in the country's leadership over how far to go to strike a deal with the Americans—a concern as mediators scramble to arrange a second round of talks after the U.S. and Iran abandoned a planned meeting midweek amid rising tensions in the Strait of Hormuz.

U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner are set to go to Islamabad for talks with Iranian officials, White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said on Fox News Channel on Friday. Vice President JD Vance will be on standby to travel in case there is progress in the negotiations, she said. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi arrived in Islamabad Friday, but Iranian state media said no meeting was planned.

Tasnim, a news service affiliated with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, accused the U.S. of telling stories.

"There is basically no negotiation with the Americans at the moment, and Mr. Araghchi's trip to Islamabad is not to negotiate with the Americans," Tasnim said.

During the fighting, Iran's leadership showed unity in its

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◆ **Conflict tests U.S. plans for defending Taiwan..... A8**
◆ **Arms makers' sales rise but not their stocks..... A8**

Prediction Markets Face Fresh Scrutiny

By Alexander Osipovich And Krystal Hur

The arrest of a soldier charged with using classified information to place lucrative bets on Polymarket is a watershed moment for prediction markets, heralding a new era of stricter government enforcement of the wildly popular betting platforms.

The case against Gannon Ken Van Dyke, a master sergeant with the U.S. Army Special Forces, marks the first U.S. prosecution for insider trading in prediction markets. It follows months of public scrutiny of suspected insider trades and market manipulation on the platforms, as well as criticism of Polymarket for offering bets on war.

Van Dyke's alleged trades—in which he made more than $400,000 by betting on the downfall of former Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro, prosecutors said—were spotted within hours of the U.S. military operation to seize Maduro in early January. The alleged trades raised suspicions of insider trading on social media and drew media coverage.

The Maduro bets were just one in a series of controversies that have swirled around Polymarket's unregulated offshore platform, which has long had an edgy, anything-goes culture. The platform uses

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EXCHANGE

Breakthrough Heart Procedure Comes With Risky Tradeoffs

New valves save lives, but don't last as long as some hoped

By Betsy McKay

After months of dizziness and arms aching so badly she could barely walk her dog, Susan Glannan lay stunned in a sunny hospital room as a doctor told her she should have open heart surgery.

The idea of a surgeon cracking her chest open and stopping her heart terrified her. Glannan, who was 64, lived alone. She didn't have her affairs in order. And just four years earlier, she had had a procedure that she thought would take care of her heart problem—a diseased aortic valve. "I was disappointed and scared," she said, "and I started worrying, 'Do I have a will?'"

That first procedure was called a transcatheter aortic valve replacement, or TAVR. It's considered one of the biggest innovations

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A Mayor With No Pants Is the Talk of This Town

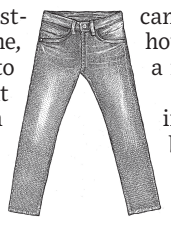
* * *

Odd night at Town Hall was caught on video, and not everyone in Mooresville is amused

By Scott Calvert

MOORESVILLE, N.C.—Dave Homick loves this fast-growing town's nickname, Race City USA, a nod to its deep Nascar ties. But he hates the attention it's getting now for a decidedly different sort of raciness.

Mooresville Mayor Chris Carney was caught with his pants down—and not in a figurative sense—inside Town Hall, on camera, during the wee hours, in the company of a female journalist.



Missing

The episode occurred in 2024 but is now bubbling up on multiple fronts. Three former town employees

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Meta's Embrace of AI Propels Huge Layoffs

By Meghan Bobrowsky

Meta Platforms just offered a glimpse at what it thinks the future of work looks like: training and supervising artificial-intelligence systems to do what used to be your job. And that's if you still have a job at all.

The social-media company has been unusually aggressive, even by the standards of Silicon Valley, at pushing to incorporate AI into employees' workflows and using it to streamline and accelerate its operations.

Already this year, it has started grading employees in performance reviews on their AI use; created ultraflat teams with almost no managers; and begun to develop a so-called CEO agent to assist Chief Executive Officer Mark Zuckerberg in performing his job. Zuckerberg and his lieutenants have repeatedly emphasized the way AI lets small teams do the work of large ones, while moving faster.

This week, the transformation kicked into high gear.

On Thursday, the company

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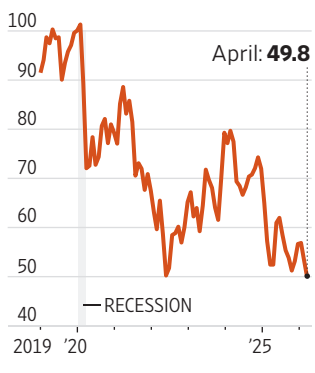
Job Angst Fuels Fears

Index of consumer sentiment hits 70-plus-year low. **A2**

Consumer-sentiment index



Source: University of Michigan